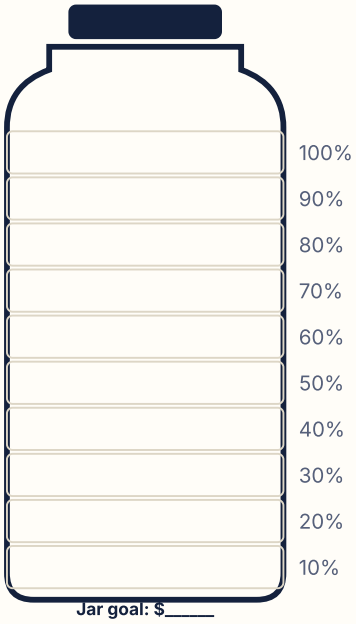
The Tax Jar Tracker

The rule: from every client payment, move your set-aside percentage into a separate tax account the same day. Colour in a band each time the jar reaches another 10% of your goal.



One step a week

- [ ] **Day 1 · Nov 16** Start: 25% of every payment, the same day it arrives
- [ ] **Week 1 · Nov 23** Open a separate savings account for tax. Nickname it
- [ ] **Week 2 · Nov 30** Find your own %: federal from the table + your state's rate
- [ ] **Week 3 · Dec 7** Backfill: your % of payments since Sep 1
- [ ] **Week 4 · Dec 14** Decide: % of the whole payment (simple) or of profit
- [ ] **Week 5 · Dec 21** Automate: invoice reminder, Friday transfer or bank rule
- [ ] **Week 6 · Dec 28** Check the jar against your Jan 15 payment
- [ ] **Week 7 · Jan 4** Set up IRS Direct Pay: 1040-ES, tax year 2026
- [ ] **Week 8 · Jan 11** Leftover beyond the payment stays for April 15
- [ ] **Jan 15** Pay from the jar. Save the confirmation number

Your percentage (2026 federal, single filer, no other income)

Expected profit	$30,000	$60,000	$90,000	$120,000
Federal set-aside	17.3%	20.1%	21.5%	23.7%

Add your state's income tax rate. With a day job, freelance income is taxed on top of your wages, so it's often closer to 30%. Jar goal: your Jan 15 payment (smaller of 90% of 2026 tax or 100% of 2025 tax, 110% if 2025 AGI was over $150,000, minus what you've paid) plus a cushion for April 15.

My jar %: _____ **My Jan 15 payment: $_____** **Tax account: _____**

Educational content, not tax advice. 2026 federal figures.

PAYMENTS LOG

Every payment, every set-aside

One line per client payment. "In the jar" is the payment times your %. Keep a running total and compare it with your goal in week 6.

Date	Client	Payment	Jar %	In the jar	Jar total
Example	*Fictional client*	*$2,000*	*25%*	*$500*	*$500*

Jan 15, 2027: pay at irs.gov/payments (Direct Pay or your online account). Choose estimated tax, Form 1040-ES, tax year 2026. Whatever stays in the jar is for April 15.

Example numbers are fictional, not a promise.